

“We always believed that open source is here to stay”



Born and brought up in the capital of India, **Mukul Mahajan, director-sales, Tetra Information Services (P) Ltd**, started his career at Pertech Computers Limited. But, as it is said, destiny has its own plans. The shutting down of Pertech presented him with an opportunity, because he had always yearned for more independence in his professional life. So he embarked on an entrepreneurial journey, with open source as one of the key building blocks of his business. In a tete-a-tete with **Syeda Beenish of OSFY**, he shares the opportunities open source offers and how much acceptance it has earned in the market. Excerpts...

Early days

After completing my B.Tech from Jaipur, I was able to successfully grab a good opportunity with Pertech Computers Limited. I worked there for about five years. Though things were going great, I felt that my life was not complete as I wanted to do something on my own.

So I started my company, Tetra Information Services (P) Ltd, in 1995. Two friends of mine, Biswajeet and Deepa, joined my startup.

When open source started taking off in the country, we could see the potential it had in the market. To be precise, the open source movement started around 1998, i.e., 20 years back, and we got involved with it right away. We were in the hardware business, and were looking at business opportunities where we could avoid

being locked in with the OEMs, in order to be in direct connect with our customers. We could see that only open source would give us that option. And, in the process, we also realised that it was a very cost-effective option. So, we adopted it as part of our business offerings. We now feel that this was the best professional decision we have taken. The motto of Tetra Information Services is, ‘We provide open source solutions for business needs’.

We sensed that open source had staying power

Realising the potential of open source, we knew that it was here to stay. So, at Tetra, we launched a mission to promote open source and take it closer to the corporates and SMEs. To do this, we started participating actively

in industry events conducted by organisations like EFY, PHDCCI, etc.

The path we’d chosen was not an easy one! It was tough to convince people about the merits of open source and propose solutions specifically meant for them. We had to convince customers about the long-term viability of the solutions.

During the first few years, the biggest challenge was convincing organisations that open source is a viable solution for them. Next, our efforts went into convincing people to pay for open source. The two things that helped us to overcome these obstacles was our faith in the technology and our persistence. We always believed that open source is here to stay, and that helped us to win customers over.